

BAHU VS

WHAT MAYA WANTS...

Central funding of Rs 80,000 Cr

- GANGA EXPRESSWAY TO CONNECT NOIDA WITH BALLIA
- YAMUNA AND HINDON EXPRESSWAYS
- Rs 3,500-CRORE TAJ INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT NEAR NOIDA
- REHAB PACKAGE FOR DROUGHT-HIT BUNDELKHAND
- INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT IN POORVANCHAL



YASBANT NEGI

The two most powerful women in the country get down and dirty as elections loom, vote-banks clash and both jostle for power in Delhi

■ By Priya Sahgal with Subhash Mishra in Rae Bareilly

The roses have long since withered. Four years ago, Congress President Sonia Gandhi had gone calling on Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Mayawati on her birthday, a bouquet of pink flowers in hand. That was then. Now, India's two most powerful women have given up bouquets for brickbats.

Confrontation, however, is not Sonia's style. Predictably it was Mayawati who fired the first salvo when she cancelled a land allotment for a rail coach factory in Rae Bareilly, barely 48 hours before Sonia was slated to perform a 'bhoomi poojan' on the land. One reason was that Mayawati was upset at not being invited for the foundation stone-laying ceremony which prevented her from taking any credit for the project. The last-minute cancellation embarrassed

Sonia on her home turf. Once attacked, no one knows how to strike back better than the Congress chief. She decided to go ahead with her Rae Bareilly visit and planned a mammoth rally targeting Mayawati as anti-development.

In the meantime, petitioned by the Congress, the Allahabad High Court stayed the cancellation but asked that status quo be maintained on the land. Even as Sonia organised a private aircraft to take her to Rae Bareilly, Mayawati struck again. She imposed Section 144 of the CrPc, which prohibits five or more people from assembling at one place, citing security considerations due to festivities. The rally was cancelled. Instead, Sonia got into her SUV and toured the 'disputed' site. "Rae Bareilly has been the *karam bhoomi* (workplace) of Indira Gandhi, Feroze Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi. This is my *karam bhoomi*. Nobody can stop me from coming home," thundered Sonia. In turn, Mayawati countered, "The Congress is worried only about Rae Bareilly but I am worried about the whole of Uttar Pradesh."

Despite Section 144, the minute Sonia's plane landed at Fursatganj airport, thousands of her supporters surrounded her, shouting "Sonia

Gandhi *sangharsh karo*" (keep fighting). Incidentally, apart from the Congressmen in the crowd, there were also BSP workers who were angry at their chief's decision to cancel a project that would create 10,000 jobs in the state. "There is no private sector development in Uttar Pradesh, people are jobless. We would have welcomed this," said Vijay Kumar Singh of the BSP in Lalganj. The police, sensing the mood of the people, failed to enforce Section 144 as Sonia's cavalcade rolled triumphantly through the streets.

Pushed to the defensive, Mayawati hurriedly called a press conference within 24 hours of Sonia's departure and blamed the Congress for blocking development in the state. "Mayawati has now provided us with an issue—that she is anti-development. This is the first big project coming up in Uttar Pradesh after many years," retaliated R.P.N. Singh, an MLA and Congress leader. Mayawati took a leaf out of Mamata Banerjee's book in far away West Bengal and claimed that the farmers had objected to the land being taken away. "No farmer is protesting," countered Jitin Prasada, Congress MP and Union minister. "They are happy getting both compensation and jobs."